



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Lionheart Classical Academy
School Website: <https://lionheartclassical.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Lionheart Classical Academy NH 03458 (Peterborough, NH) presents a clearly identified classical-education orientation anchored in virtue formation, liberal-arts curriculum, and Hillsdale College alignment. Public-facing materials foreground a mission to train minds and inspire hearts through a classical Liberal Arts and Sciences education that emphasizes virtuous living, responsible citizenship, high academic standards, and cultural literacy. The school describes itself as tuition-free, serving grades K–8, with a view toward a K–12 classical identity and a vision of forming “virtuous” citizens with intellectual curiosity and a love of learning. A Hillsdale-affiliated curriculum is explicitly marketed, alongside a commitment to a content-rich, classical approach and a focus on virtuous character and civic virtue. However, there is no explicit articulation of religious/theological foundations or liturgical/community practices on the public-facing materials (and the FAQ notes that charter schools are not religious), which affects Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations). The public materials also signal ongoing enrollment practices (lottery/waitlist), open access for NH residents, and active parent engagement, which supports Element 6 (Parents & Community).

Overall classification by category (using the Six Essential Elements lexicon as the rubric):

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Aggregate assessment: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Key insights: - The school's public materials robustly articulate virtue, moral character, and cultural literacy as core aims, and the Hillsdale-aligned liberal-arts curriculum is central to its classical identity (Element 2, Element 3 to some extent). - Element 1 reflects a secular orientation with explicit charitable statements about being “not religious” in the charter context, which prevents full alignment with religious/metaphysical foundations. - Pedagogy, faculty, and some curricular details are present but do not consistently demonstrate all classical-method markers (e.g., explicit mention of Socratic seminars, rigorous memory-work, or the full Great Books framework appear only indirectly or not at all in public-facing text), yielding a mixed (Somewhat Classical) signal across Categories 3–5. - Element 6 shows stronger classical-community alignment through parent partnership, formation activities, and open-access policies, aligning with Classical indicators.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes virtue, moral character, and transcendent-type aims in statements about forming virtuous citizens (Our Mission and Our Goals). It foregrounds a moral/virtue framework rather than explicit theology or liturgical practices. The public FAQ even notes charter schools are not religious. - Our

Mission: virtuous living and responsible citizenship. - Vision emphasizes strong moral character. - What is a classical education? frames virtue in a moral-civic context. - FAQ notes “they are not religious.”

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: virtue, virtuous, moral character, civic virtue, moral realism (conceptually linked to virtue and character formation), cultural literacy (moral/civic formation). - Examples: virtuous living, strong moral character, moral and civic emphasis. - Negative indicators present: explicit theological/theological-liturgical language is absent; explicit religious liturgy is not referenced; the charter is described as not religious.

Why this rating - The materials foreground virtue and moral character without explicit theological or liturgical grounding, and they explicitly state non-religious status for charter schools. This yields a partial alignment with Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL) rather than a full CLASSICAL signal.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission and goals center on formation, virtue, wisdom, and human excellence rather than mere job-readiness. The text emphasizes virtuous living, citizenship, cultural literacy, and a classical mission that seeks to cultivate human excellence. - Our Mission emphasizes virtuous living and responsible citizenship. - Our Vision emphasizes moral character and a culture of high expectations. - Our Goals emphasize virtuous graduates who are highly literate and culturally literate, prepared for ongoing achievement and citizenship. - Curriculum alignment with liberal-arts, classical education, and Hillsdale-based content.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, liberal education, classical mission, telos, great conversation (implicit in “content-rich”/classical orientation), civic virtue, moral imagination, cultural literacy. - Examples: formation, liberal arts, classical mission, telos, cultural literacy, virtue. - Negative indicators present: none evident in the public materials for this category (no explicit job-readiness emphasis); the focus is on formation and virtue.

Why this rating - The materials repeatedly articulate formation, virtue, wisdom, and a classical mission (with emphasis on liberal arts and cultural literacy), aligning with the CLASSICAL orientation for School Purpose and Goal.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum is described as liberal-arts heavy and Hillsdale-aligned, with a focus on a content-rich classical education and a K–12 Hillsdale curriculum, including core disciplines and a broad liberal-arts emphasis. - Curriculum from Hillsdale College; Hillsdale-based K-12 program; four core disciplines of math, science, literature, and history; plus arts and languages. - Academics page emphasizes a full liberal-arts education and a content-rich, classical curriculum with civic virtues. - The mission and curriculum language stresses a robust classical curriculum and cultural literacy. - Negative indicators present: explicit references in the lexicon to “social studies terminology replacing history,” “STEM-first framing,” and “project-based learning dominance,” which signal departures from a traditional historical/humanistic curriculum emphasis. - Negative signals listed in classical-lexicon (applied to the school’s curriculum context): social studies terminology replacing history; STEM-first framing; project-based learning dominance.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, classical education, content-rich curriculum, Hillsdale Curriculum School, four core disciplines (math, science, literature, history), cultural literacy, classical heritage. - Examples: liberal arts, classical education, content-rich, Hillsdale Curriculum School, four core disciplines. - Negative keywords present: social studies terminology replacing history; STEM-first framing; project-based learning dominance.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates strong liberal-arts and classical-curriculum signals (CLASSICAL), but explicit pedagogy and the presence of negative signals around curriculum framing (e.g., possible emphasis away from history, STEM-first framing, or project-based dominance) push the rating toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public-facing descriptions emphasize a classical approach and big questions, with a general sense of a content-rich program. Explicit pedagogy terms such as Socratic seminars, chant/singing, or liturgical/scholastic memory work are not clearly described in public materials, but the phrase “asks big questions” appears in the classical-education framing. - What is a classical education? frames education as addressing intellectual, moral, and civic virtue, with questions and beauty; emphasizes a content-rich approach and big questions. - The Academics content describes a liberal-arts, content-rich approach as a foundation for learning and memory of curriculum; but explicit lower- vs upper-school pedagogy markers (Socratic, seminars, singing, chanting, etc.) are not enumerated in the public text. - Enrollment and other pages emphasize structure and mission, not explicit spacing for contemplative/restful pedagogy beyond general virtue formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: contemplation and wonder language from the classical-education framing; emphasis on big questions and a content-rich approach. - Example: “asks big questions” and emphasis on a classical approach. - Negative indicators present: lack of explicit statements about lower-grade singing/chanting, Socratic seminars, or upper-grade rhetoric/debate in public-facing materials; absence of detailed contemplative/restful pedagogy markers beyond general scholé framing.

Why this rating - The school clearly identifies as classical and emphasizes big questions and content-rich pedagogy, but explicit, codified evidence of the full pedagogical methods typical of a classic program (Socratic seminars, memory work, chanting, and formal rhetoric/debate) is not clearly documented in public materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize teachers as capable of guiding a classical curriculum and being part of a virtuous mission, with language suggesting teachers are central to the school’s character and culture. There are staff pages and job postings, indicating an emphasis on teacher quality and fit with mission. - Employment opportunities page highlights the role of teachers and mentors and describes teaching roles in a classical setting. - Mission and values statements imply teachers model virtue and serve as living examples in a classical environment (Training Minds and Inspiring Hearts). - Staff and administration pages emphasize the public-facing culture of teaching and learning (staff listing/board interactions).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: model teachers and mentors, living curriculum concepts, partnership between teachers and students, collegial culture (as suggested by job postings and mission statements). - Example: “Living curriculum” concept appears in classical-education lexicon as a positive marker; the school demonstrates language that positions teachers as core to the school’s classical mission. - Negative indicators present: explicit statements about “certification-driven jargon” or “facilitators/guides on the side” are not present in the school’s public materials; there is some lack of explicit quotes like “portrait of a teacher” in public text. The absence constitutes a relative weakness for a strong, explicit faculty identity in classical terms. - Negative signals in the lexicon include “facilitators,” “guides on the side,” and “certification-driven jargon without classical context”; these are not seen in public-facing Lionheart texts, so the presence is minimal.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates a classical ethos with teachers positioned as central to pedagogy and mission; however, explicit articulations of the living-curriculum portrait or a formalized faculty model are not strongly documented in public materials. The signals thus align with SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for the Faculty category.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnerships with parents, parent formation, and active family engagement; open campus and public events are referenced; parent information and enrollment materials indicate active parent involvement and communication about classical education. - Parent Information pages and

enrollment materials indicate a proactive approach to parent engagement and community involvement. - Enrollment and information sessions are described as opportunities for prospective families to learn about classical education, with multiple communications channels (email, newsletters, events). - The public materials show open access for visits and involvement, with parent-facing sections (FAQ, enrollment, events, board information) and “Training Minds and Inspiring Hearts” messaging that invites family participation. - Addressing the public: “Lionheart Classical Academy is a licensee of Hillsdale’s K-12 Program” helps build community credibility and a shared classical framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: partnership with parents, co-teachers concept (as found in the classical lexicon), parent formation, reading groups, seminars/book clubs, open campus, family involvement, and parent communications. - Examples in public text include parent information, enrollment sessions, and events. - Negative indicators present: none significant in public materials; the school presents a proactive, welcoming posture toward parents rather than a consumer-model approach. - The public-facing FAQ explicitly rejects religious discrimination in admissions but does not present consumer-focused language.

Why this rating - Lionheart’s public materials consistently frame parents as partners and co-educators in a classical model, with ample opportunities for parent involvement and education about classical education. This aligns strongly with CLASSICAL for Parents & Community.

What would move the needle

- For Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Include explicit language about transcendent moral order, shared liturgical or communal practices (even if non-denominational), or theological grounding to demonstrate deeper metaphysical alignment. A cautious, secular articulation could be maintained, but adding a stated tradition or contemplative practice would push Element 1 toward CLASSICAL.
- For Element 3 (Curriculum): Explicitly name and demonstrate the presence of Great Books, primary sources, and the grammar/logic/rhetoric sequence; clarify the role of classical languages (Latin/Greek) and explicit historical narrative (not just Western civilization). Incorporate language about not substituting history with social-studies framing and reduce or contextualize STEM-first narratives with balanced emphasis on humanities.
- For Element 4 (Pedagogy): Add explicit mention of Socratic seminars, memory work (recitation, dictation), and a formal sequence of rhetoric and oratory in upper grades; demonstrate daily or weekly practice of contemplation/scholé, and show examples of student-led seminars or debates.
- For Element 5 (Faculty): Strengthen and publicly articulate the living-curriculum concept, a formal portrait of teacher expectations, and a clearly defined teacher-professional-development pathway aligned with classical pedagogy; emphasize mentor-model teacher profiles and a “faculty as living curriculum” statement in public materials.
- For Element 6 (Parents & Community): While this area already reads CLASSICAL, the school could strengthen forms of parental formation (book clubs, study groups), formal family liturgy alignment, and explicit home-learning partnerships to deepen the co-teaching model.
- General needle-movers (cross-category): Publish a concise “Classical Education Playbook” on the website that explicitly lists the six elements (grammar/logical/rhetoric sequence, Great Books/Great Conversation, memory work, contemplation/scholé, rhetoric (upper grades), and living curriculum) with concrete, public examples from Lionheart’s program. This would provide clearer alignment across all six categories and help visitors see how the school implements classical education in practice.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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